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Tuition Assistance and Staff Expense Reimbursement

Tuition Assistance

HCCS will establish a pool of \$30,000 for tuition assistance each school year to promote education and development of professional skills for its employees.

1. Application Guidelines

- a. Process: Prior to beginning classes, employees must first discuss development goals with their supervisors and complete the Tuition Assistance Application. Employees submit the completed application to the administrator/principal or designee. Applications are reviewed four times per year. Employees are notified of the award decisions in writing within two weeks of receipt of the application. Incomplete and late applications will not be accepted.
- b. Eligibility: Funding is available to all regular employees who:
 - (1) Are budgeted hours per week and maintain that status while completing course work.
 - (2) Have completed six months of employment.
 - (3) Have not been under any disciplinary action within the past 12 months or at the time of reimbursement.
- c. Criteria: Applications are assessed for the following criteria:
 - (1) The course is aligned with the vision, mission, and goals of the organization.
 - (2) The education provided skills and knowledge needed in the future at HCCS.
 - (3) The education will increase HCCS's workforce flexibility.
 - (4) The education has a reasonable relationship to education.
 - (5) The education can be used in the employee's current position.
- d. Approval Required: Coursework beginning before approval is granted will not be considered for reimbursement.
- e. Dates: Tuition assistance is based on the fiscal year. Applications are accepted four times per year:
 - (1) Fall term: Classes starting between September 1st and November 30th
 - (2) Winter term: Classes starting between December 1st and February 28th
 - (3) Spring term: Classes starting between March 1st and May 31st
 - (4) Summer term: Classes starting between June 1st and August 31st

2. Coursework Guidelines

- a. Accreditation: Tuition reimbursement will only be awarded for coursework from accredited U.S. secondary schools, colleges, and universities. For the purposes of this procedure, accredited schools are listed on the U.S. Department of Education website at <http://opec.ed.gov/accreditation/>

- b. Scheduling: Classes must be taken outside of normally scheduled work time. Employees will not be reimbursed for time spent in class on coursework.
- c. Degree Programs: Coursework must apply towards a baccalaureate or graduate degree or endorsement. Exam fees and certification fees are not reimbursable.
- d. Changes in Coursework: Employees must notify the administrator/principal or supervisor of any changes in coursework or the non-use of funds in writing in order to remain eligible for tuition assistance. Failure to do so will result in future denials.

3. Reimbursement Guidelines

- a. Process: Final grade(s) and a detailed receipt must be submitted to the human resources/business manager within 30 calendar days of class completion using the Expense Report form. Any reimbursement claims submitted after 30 calendar days of course completion may be denied. Receipts and final grade documentation must have the employee's full name and the name of the post-secondary school. Reimbursement will be issued within 30 calendar days of receipt of documentation by HCCS.
- b. Eligible expenses: Employees will be reimbursed for tuition costs only.
- c. Ineligible expenses:
 - (1) Books
 - (2) Lab fees
 - (3) Application fees
 - (4) Technology fees
 - (5) Software
 - (6) Student activity fees
 - (7) Fines
 - (8) Lodging
 - (9) Shipping
 - (10) Supplies and equipment
 - (11) Transportation and parking fees
 - (12) Exam or certification fees
 - (13) Recertification fees
- d. Grades: Reimbursement will only be offered for courses completed with a grade of "C" (2.0) or better for undergraduate level and "B" (3.0) or better for graduate level.
- e. Annual and Lifetime Maximums: HCCS reimburses employees up to a maximum of \$3,000 annually. Percentage may vary term to term based on the availability of funds.
- f. Limitations: Reimbursement is limited to the amount approved on the initial application.
- g. Other Financial Assistance: Employees must disclose other sources of financial assistance including grants and scholarships at the time of application. Failure to do so will result in future denials of tuition assistance. Employees may not receive more than 100 percent of eligible expenses after accounting for funding from other sources.

Expense and Travel Reimbursement

Expense reimbursement for staff traveling on approved HCCS business will be governed by the following procedures. "Travel expenses" include travel fares, meals and lodging and expenses incident to travel. Only travel expenses as are ordinary and necessary in the conduct of approved travel for school business purposes and directly attributable to it will be reimbursed. As used in this regulation an "ordinary" expense means one that is common and accepted in the profession; a "necessary" expense means one that is essential and appropriate in order to conduct school business.

Reimbursement procedures established by HCCS will also apply to Board members traveling on Board-approved school business, as applicable.

Travel by employees that is more than 25 miles from HCCS and takes the employee out-of-state require prior approval from the administrator/principal.

Out-of-country travel plans require prior approval from the HCCS Board.

Insurance Coverage

1. Insurance costs are included as part of the mileage reimbursement for employees authorized to use a private vehicle to conduct school business. It is the responsibility of the owner or driver of the vehicle to be certain that the vehicle is adequately covered by insurance.
2. The responsibility of the school for damages resulting from vehicle accidents is not the same as set forth in the school's general liability insurance policy. The employee's insurance coverage provides primary coverage when the employee is driving their own vehicle on approved school business.
3. All employees operating private vehicles on approved school business are required to complete and maintain on file with HCCS verification of vehicle liability insurance that meets or exceeds Oregon statutory minimum limits. This verification is required annually. Employees are required to update their verification of vehicle liability information maintained on file with HCCS upon **any** change in the employee's vehicle insurance coverage.

Meals and Meetings

1. Reimbursement will be made for ordinary and necessary meal expenses incurred in the course of approved travel for school business. Meals include amounts spent for food, beverage, taxes and related gratuities. Purchase of alcoholic beverages will not be reimbursed by the school. See **Expense Reimbursement Request and Accounting Procedures** below.
2. Expenses in excess of the school's established limit are ordinarily the responsibility of the employee and may be reimbursed only with approval from the administrator/principal or designee. Receipts for all meal expenses must be secured and attached to the claim.

Travel Advances

1. A travel advance may be requested when the estimated cost for meals, lodging, etc., exceeds \$50. The travel advance request may be submitted to the director of operations or designee.
2. The cost of commercial travel tickets will not be included in a cash advance request.
3. In the event of loss, the employee is personally responsible for cash advances issued and for any third-party use of a HCCS-provided credit card.
4. At least 10 working days are required for processing an advance check after the approved request is received by the business office.
5. Only one cash advance may be outstanding to any employee at any time.

Reservations, Commercial Carrier, and Lodging

1. Travel must be conducted in the most expeditious and cost-effective manner by HCCS.
2. Each employee is responsible for making their own reservations with approval from the administrator/principal or director of operations.

Vehicle Rentals

1. Rental vehicles may be used only when use will affect a savings or otherwise be more advantageous to HCCS or when the use of other transportation is not feasible.
2. Rental of a compact vehicle is recommended when suitable for approved school business because of the lower initial rate and the guaranteed rate. Certain rental agencies guarantee the compact rate in all owned stations and in most licensee stations.
3. Rental vehicles will be used only for official travel or in lieu of taxi for necessary travel. Any additional costs incurred for other usage will be the personal responsibility of the traveler.
4. Employees will be informed if HCCS carries the rental car endorsement as part of its insurance coverage. In the event HCCS does not carry the rental car endorsement the employee will need to gain authorization to purchase insurance coverage from the rental agency.

Cancelled Trips

1. If an employee cannot leave at the scheduled time, it is the employee's responsibility to call the travel agency or carrier and arrange to have the tickets and/or reservations cancelled or exchanged.
2. Commercial carrier reservation cancellations must be made at least 24 hours before departure time, whenever possible.
3. Lodging reservations must be cancelled by the employee as soon as possible to avoid a cancellation charge.
4. If a trip is cancelled after an advance and/or tickets have been issued, the advance and tickets must be returned to the business office immediately.

Personal Travel Combined with HCCS Business Travel

1. If an individual traveling on approved school business engages in both business and personal activities, travel expenses incurred will be reimbursed only for expenses that are ordinary and necessary in the conduct of public charter school business. Expenses incurred as a part of personal business are the sole responsibility of the traveler.
2. When personal travel is combined with approved school business travel and the individual is traveling by less than the most expeditious and cost-effective manner, any additional costs must be paid by the traveler.
3. Time away from work caused by traveling by less than the most expeditious means available for personal purposes must be charged to vacation or other appropriate leave.
4. Vacation or other personal leave may be taken in conjunction with approved school travel subject to the following:
 - a. Time delays related to approved school business are charged as working time even if no work is performed;
 - b. If the employee travels by less than the most cost-effective manner, as determined by HCCS, for approved school business or for personal travel combined with travel for school business purposes, the employee must pay the additional cost (e.g., increased fare, meals, lodging expenses, etc.) incurred as a result of the personal travel;
 - c. All subsistence and local transportation (e.g., taxi, vehicle fare, etc.) while on vacation status or other appropriate leave must be paid by the employee;

- d. The traveler will not be required to pay any of the basic transportation costs incurred as a part of the approved school business, even though the employee spends a substantial part of the total time away from home on vacation or other personal leave, provided the employee was traveling on approved school business;
- e. A traveler who decides to conduct school business on their own time without prior approval, while on vacation or other personal leave, cannot then use this as a justification to have the school pay their basic transportation cost from the school to the location visited, or submit a request for other expense reimbursement.

Expense Reimbursement Request and Accounting Procedures

1. Reimbursement requests detailing actual expenditures must be submitted on the school's expense form and approved by the administrator/principal or designee in writing. Receipts and supporting documentation must accompany all expense reimbursement requests. This includes, but is not limited to, receipts for transportation, lodging, meals, registration, conference and workshop fees. All requests must be submitted to the school office within 30 calendar days of the conclusion of the trip.
 - a. If the completed expense report totals less than the travel advance, the difference must be returned within 15 working days to the business office with the report.
 - b. Reimbursement for expenditures in excess of a travel advance, or where no travel advance has been requested, will be made within 30 calendar days after the approved travel expense report is received by the business office.
2. Expenses which consist primarily of the cost of furnishing meals for others will be reimbursed upon submission of a travel expense report which includes:
 - a. The names of guests;
 - b. The organizations involved;
 - c. A full explanation of the school business purpose of the meeting.
3. In the event a vehicle was rented, a copy of the rental agreement must be attached to the travel expense report. The rental charge should be paid from the amount advanced, as applicable. Purchase of gas and oil which have been deducted from the rental charge by the rental agency must be included.
4. Any claim for mileage reimbursement only may be submitted at the end of each month in which reimbursement is to be claimed. A claim must be submitted no later than 60 calendar days of incurring the expense. Reimbursement claims later than 60 calendar days of the expense will be denied.
5. Mileage for approved school business travel in a private vehicle will be reimbursed at the current rate per mile established by the school or Internal Revenue Service (IRS), as applicable. Reimbursement that exceeds the IRS rate will be included as income to the employee in accordance with IRS regulations.
6. Meal expenses for approved school business travel purposes, may be reportable as income to the employee in accordance with IRS regulations. Generally, meal expenses incurred for approved school business purposes in which school business is conducted with at least one or more other persons, or that is incurred on approved school business for a trip that is overnight, or long enough that the individual needs to stop for sleep or rest to properly perform their duties, as defined by the IRS, will not be reportable as income to the employee.
7. In the event the total of the amount charged to, and/or received from the school by the employee as advances, reimbursement or otherwise, exceeds the ordinary and necessary business expenses, the excess must be reported as income in accordance with IRS requirements.

Reimbursable Expense Limitations

1. Meal expenses may be reimbursed subject to the following limitations:

Allowance:	Breakfast	\$14
	Lunch	\$16
	Dinner	\$26
2. Gratuities must not exceed 15 percent and must be included as a part of the receipt. Gratuities in excess of 15 percent are the responsibility of the employee and will not be reimbursed by the public charter school.
3. Other expenses such as toll charges, parking fees, valet services, cleaning, pressing and laundry may be reimbursed if length of a trip or circumstances demand.
4. Mileage reimbursement for actual miles traveled on school business, may be approved subject to the following limitations:
 - a. Mileage reimbursement will not be granted to an employee, other than a school-approved tutor, for traveling from their residence to the place where work begins for the day or for returning home from the last place worked during the day;
 - b. Reimbursement will be made only for those miles actually traveled in the course of completing approved school business. When chauffeured, mileage for two round trips and short-term parking will be reimbursed if not greater than the cost of one round trip plus economy parking;
 - c. Group travel may be requested on one travel request form for a group traveling together as long as advance and reimbursement is payable to one person who has complete responsibility for reporting expenses;
 - d. In the event a private vehicle is approved for use from home, to or from airport or railroad station, mileage for one round trip and economy parking will be reimbursed. Parking receipts are required;
 - e. Individuals requesting reimbursement for use of a private vehicle on approved school business must meet insurance requirements. See **Insurance Coverage** above.
5. Lodging will be reimbursed at reasonable commercial rates.
6. Local taxi, shuttle, ride shares, bus fares, and vehicle rentals may be reimbursed, subject to the school's requirement that travel selected is by the most expeditious, cost-effective manner, as determined by HCCS.